

Red Zone, Goal Line, Two-Point Plays, and Short Yardage (Including the Tush Push)

Why football gets harder as the end zone gets closer, and the plays built for the last twenty yards and the last yard

Third-and-goal from the 6. For three quarters this offense has gone up and down the field: its receivers have been open, its quarterback has had time, its average play has gained six yards. Now, with the end zone close enough to hit with a thrown helmet, it gains one yard on first down, nothing on second, and on third the quarterback holds the ball, finds nobody, and throws it out of the back of the end zone. The kicker comes on. The announcer sighs about “red-zone efficiency” as if the offense had lost its nerve. It didn’t. The field got smaller, and a smaller field is a different game: some plays stop working, others start, and the defense gets to do things it could never do at midfield. This chapter is about that different game, from the 20-yard line to the last inch.

You’ll be able to:

- Explain the **compressed field**: why deep zones vanish near the goal line, why man coverage and press take over, and what that does to the offense’s options.
- Recognize the main red-zone pass concepts on a broadcast (the fade, the back-shoulder throw, the slant, the rub, the shovel pass and the sprint-out) and say which coverage each is built to beat.
- Sketch two or three good two-point plays from the 2 and explain why they are good bets.
- Identify goal-line personnel on both sides, including the 6-2 and 5-3 goal-line defenses, and say why “low man wins” there.
- Explain how the quarterback sneak and the tush push work, the 2005 rule change that made pushing legal, and where the ban debate stands for 2026.
- Read the numbers: how often red-zone trips end in touchdowns, how each yard closer changes the odds, how often two-point tries and sneaks succeed, and what those rates do and don’t tell you.

i You’ll need

- **Third Down: The Money Down**: down-and-distance buckets, the line to gain (the “sticks”), and the defense’s situational packages and pressures. This chapter moves the same thinking to the end of the field.
- **Contact Rules and Penalties as Strategy**: offensive pass interference (a receiver may not block a defender more than a yard downfield before the pass is touched), which decides when a rub becomes an illegal pick.
- **Option Football**: why a quarterback who runs adds a blocker (the “extra hat”), and QB power, the designed quarterback run.
- Helpful too: Man Coverage (Cover 0 and Cover 1, press technique, banjo calls against stacks) and the rub route from Dropback Concepts.

How to read the diagrams. Offense is blue circles, defense orange squares, and *left* and *right* always mean the offense’s. On offense, Q is the quarterback, R the running back, F a fullback, X and Z the wide receivers, H the slot receiver, and Y and U tight ends; C is the center, and the other linemen are unlettered unless a picture needs them. On defense, E and T are the ends and tackles of the defensive line, N a nose tackle, M, W and S linebackers, CB a cornerback, \$ the nickel back (the fifth defensive back), and SS and FS the safeties. Solid blue arrows are routes, the thick dark arrow is the ball carrier, lines ending in a short bar are blocks, dotted orange lines are man-coverage assignments, dashed orange lines are a defender’s path, and brown dashes are the ball in the air. The shaded rectangle at the top of most pictures is the end zone.

The field runs out

Start with geometry, because everything in this chapter follows from it. The **red zone** is the last 20 yards before the goal line. Behind the goal line is the end zone, 10 yards deep, and behind that the **end line**, the back edge of the playable field. A pass caught beyond the end line is out of bounds. So from the opponent’s 20, the offense has at most 30 yards to work with; from the 10, 20 yards; from the 2, where two-point tries are snapped, 12.

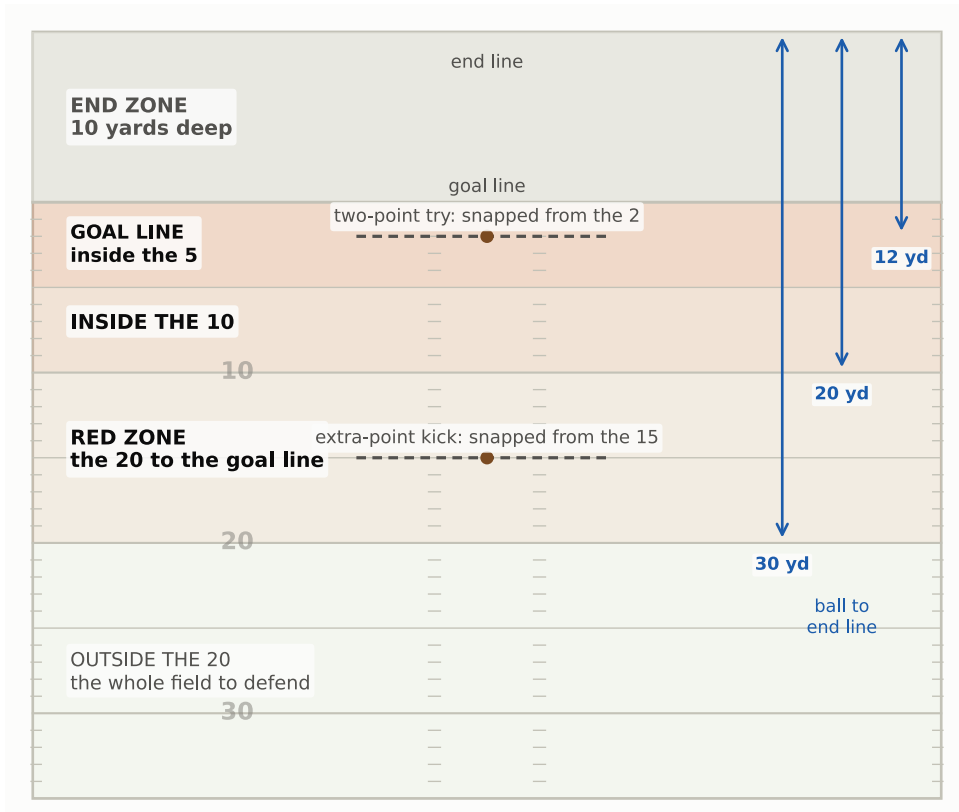
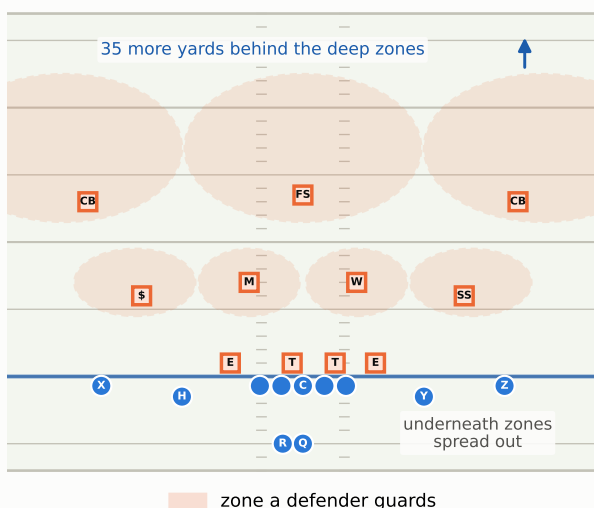


Figure 1: The last 35 yards of the field, offense moving up the page. The red zone starts at the 20; inside the 10 and inside the 5, the offense and defense change personnel and plays. Two snaps happen at fixed spots: the extra-point kick from the 15 and the two-point try from the 2. The arrows on the right show the whole depth the defense has to protect, from the ball to the end line, from three spots: it shrinks from 30 yards to 12.

Why does that matter so much? Because of what defenses do between the 20s. A normal defense spends its safeties, and sometimes its corners, on the deepest part of the field, 15, 25, 40 yards away, because a receiver who gets behind everyone there scores. The defense has to keep its depth. Near the goal line that problem disappears: the end line protects the deepest part of the field for free. It is the twelfth defender that never misses a tackle. Every defender who had been guarding grass 30 yards downfield is now available to do something else: crowd the receivers, cover a man, or rush. That is the **compressed field**: less grass to defend, the same eleven defenders to defend it.

At midfield



At the opponent's 10

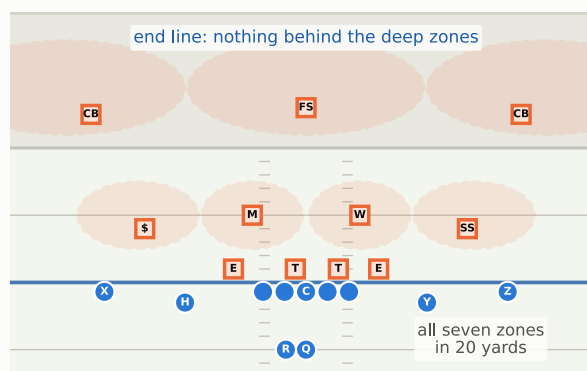


Figure 2: The same Cover 3 (three deep defenders, four underneath; see the Cover 3 chapter) at midfield and at the opponent's 10. Left: the three deep zones start 12 to 13 yards deep and still have 35 yards of field behind them, so the deep defenders must keep backing up and the underneath zones are far apart. Right: the deep zones are squeezed into the end zone against the end line. All seven zones fit into 20 yards of depth, so the windows between defenders are small and throws must be perfect. Shaded ovals are zones; the defenders are drawn where they end their drops.

Defenses use that freedom in three ways, and you can see all three on any red-zone snap.

Deep zones shrink, then disappear. A zone defense asks defenders to guard areas. Near the goal line the deep areas get squeezed against the end line until they are barely deeper than the underneath ones, and the spaces between defenders, the “windows” a quarterback throws into, close up. Inside the 10 many defenses stop pretending: with no deep middle to protect, they bring the safeties down. In FTN’s charting of 2023–2025 dropbacks, two-deep shells (Cover 2, Cover 4 and their relatives, which keep two safeties deep) were called on 44% of plays outside the red zone but only 19% inside the 5.¹

Man coverage and press take over. Man coverage’s great weakness is the receiver who beats his man deep, with no help behind. Near the goal line, “deep” doesn’t exist: a receiver who runs past his man runs out of the end zone. So defenses play much more man coverage, and much more of it **press**, with the defender a yard from the receiver at the snap, jamming him to wreck the timing. In Man Coverage you saw that charters label roughly four in five dropbacks inside the 5 as man, and that **Cover 0** (man coverage with nobody deep at all) becomes the single most common call there.

The box fills up. Every defender not needed in deep coverage can line up near the ball. That squeezes the run game: the extra defenders take away the cutback lanes and the creases a running back finds between the 20s.

The offense suffers in quieter ways too. Its deep routes are gone, so the threat that stretches the defense vertically, the one that keeps safeties honest between the 20s, is gone with them. Every route is shorter, so every throw arrives with defenders closer to the catch point. Yards after the catch shrink, because there are fewer yards left to gain. And the playbook narrows: concepts that need 15 or 20 yards of depth to develop (the deep crosser, the post, most of Dropback Concepts) simply don’t fit.

¹This book’s calculation from nflverse `load_participation()` joined to play-by-play: regular-season dropbacks, 2023–2025 (all charted by FTN, one source), with a charted `defense_coverage_type`, excluding BLOWN, COMBO and PREVENT. Two-deep = COVER_2, 2_MAN, COVER_4, COVER_6 and COVER_9. “Outside the red zone” = more than 20 yards from the goal line. Coverage labels are a charter’s judgment, and the 2018–2022 (NGS) labels are coded differently, so the comparison is kept within one source.

! Why it exists

The compressed field isn't a scheme; it's a consequence of the rulebook's geometry. But it explains a whole family of schemes. Defenses get more aggressive near the goal line because the end line gives them deep help for free: man coverage, press and Cover 0 are cheap there in a way they never are at midfield. Offenses answer with plays that win *quickly and close to the line* (slants, rubs, fades thrown before the safety can help, quarterback runs) or that create a numbers advantage the defense can't cover. The trade: everything is faster and more crowded, so mistakes cost more. A tipped ball near the goal line is an interception risk in a crowd; a one-yard loss on third-and-goal can be the difference between seven points and three.

What each yard is worth

The numbers make the squeeze concrete. Across the 2022–2025 regular seasons, 8,603 drives ran at least one play inside the opponent's 20. Of those, 60% ended in a touchdown and 26% in a field goal; the rest ended in turnovers, failed fourth downs, missed kicks or the end of a half.² That 4-point gap between a touchdown (with its extra point) and a field goal is the whole economics of the red zone, and it is why coaches judge their red-zone offense by the share of trips that end in touchdowns, not by yards.

Look closer and the value of each yard is steep. The chart follows every drive that reached a first-and-goal and asks how often it ended in a touchdown, depending on where that first-and-goal was snapped.

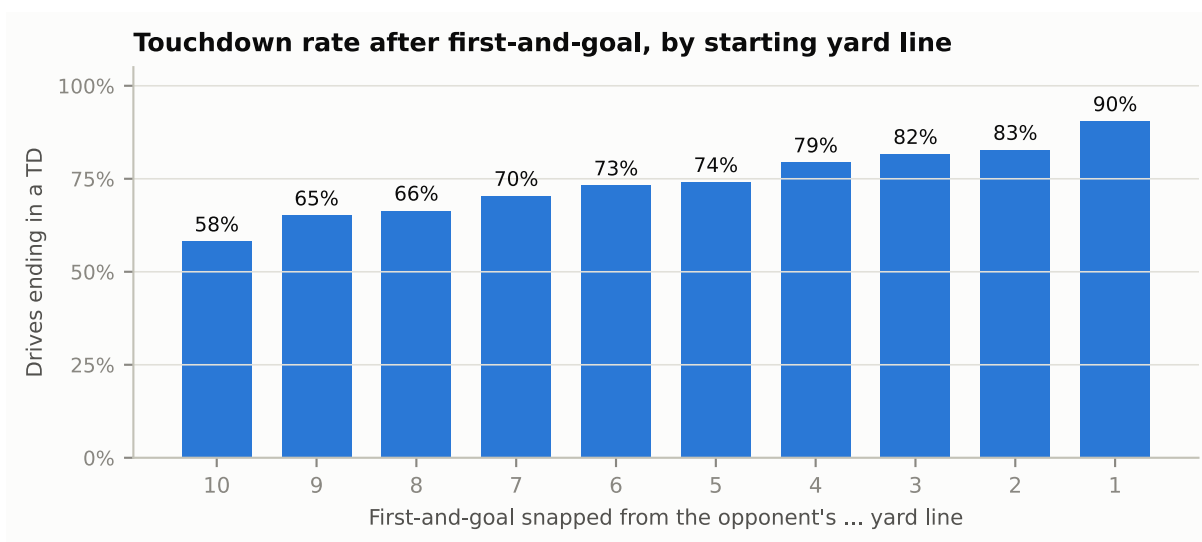


Figure 3: How often a drive scored a touchdown after reaching first-and-goal at each yard line, 2022–2025 regular seasons. From the 1, nine drives in ten score; from the 10, under six in ten. The bars count only the first first-and-goal snap of each drive, so a drive that moved from the 8 to the 2 counts at the 8. Data: nflverse play-by-play.

Read the chart from left to right, the way the offense moves. From the 10 to the 5, each yard gained adds about 3 percentage points of touchdown chance; from the 2 to the 1, it adds about 8. Those last yards are the hardest to gain and the most valuable, which is why the last part of this chapter is devoted to plays designed to gain exactly one.

The playbook shifts with the field. In neutral situations (first to third down, neither team running away with the game, outside the last two minutes of a half), offenses passed on 55% of plays between the 11 and the 20, about the same as anywhere else on the field, but on only 41% inside the 5.³ Near the goal line the run comes back, for reasons you will see: when there are only a few yards to gain, a play that gains them by force is as good as a play that gains them by deception.

²This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`fixed_drive_result`), 2022–2025 regular seasons: every drive with at least one play snapped at the opponent's 20 or closer, counted once. The rest: turnovers about 4%, turnovers on downs about 4%, missed field goals and the end of a half about 1.5% each.

³This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2022–2025 regular seasons: dropbacks (passes, sacks and scrambles) as a share of runs and dropbacks on first to third down, with the offense's win probability between 10% and 90% and more than two minutes left in the half.

Common misconception

“At the goal line, smart teams pass; running into a crowd is old-fashioned.” From the 1, the numbers say the opposite is closer to true. In 2022–2025, dropbacks snapped from the 1 scored on 52% of plays and ordinary runs on 55%, nearly the same, while quarterback sneaks scored on 67%.⁴ A pass needs a receiver to beat tight man coverage in a tiny space; a run needs one yard. Neither play is always right. The best goal-line offenses keep both alive so the defense can’t sell out against either.

Red-zone pass concepts

Because the field is short and the coverage is tight and usually man, red-zone pass plays share a style. They are quick (the ball is out in a second or two), they attack a specific matchup or leverage, and many of them are built to create separation that man coverage can’t prevent, rather than to find holes in zones. Here are the six you will see most.

The fade

The **fade** is the simplest red-zone pass and the most argued-about. The receiver releases outside his defender and runs for the back corner of the end zone; the quarterback throws the ball high and outside, over the receiver’s outside shoulder, toward the pylon, to a spot where only the receiver can catch it. It needs room, so the receiver usually lines up with five to eight yards between himself and the sideline. And it needs a matchup: a tall receiver with strong hands, ideally against a smaller corner.

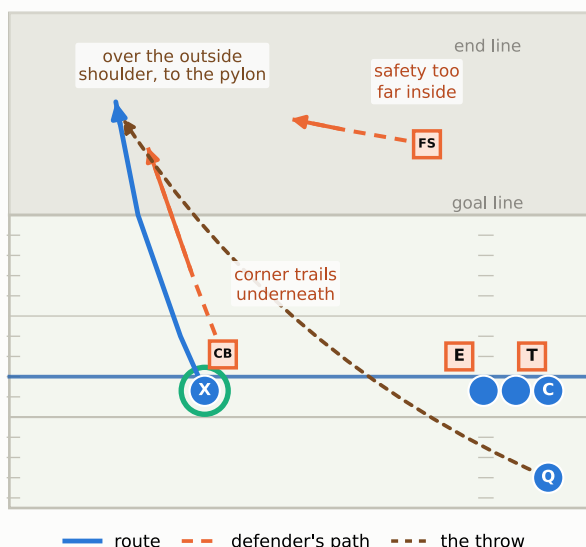
Why does it fit the red zone? The fade beats exactly what the compressed field invites: a pressed corner with no deep help outside. If the corner lines up inside the receiver (inside leverage, to take away the slant), the receiver releases outside, and the corner is left chasing from behind and inside, unable to see the ball. The safety is usually in the middle of the end zone, too far away to arrive before a ball that is in the air for barely a second.

The back-shoulder throw

Against a corner who has learned to run with the fade, stride for stride and over the top, the **back-shoulder throw** is the answer. The quarterback throws *short and behind* the receiver, to his back (outside) shoulder. The receiver, reading the throw, stops, turns back to the ball and catches it, while the defender, running full speed with his back to the quarterback, is carried a step or two past. A defender taught to take away the deep ball can’t take this away without opening the deep ball again.

⁴This book’s calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting, 2022–2025 regular seasons, every run or dropback snapped from the opponent’s 1 (kneel-downs excluded). Sneaks are plays FTN flags `is_qb_sneak`; dropbacks include sacks and scrambles. Sample sizes: 184 sneaks, 848 other runs and 371 dropbacks.

Fade: win outside, throw over the top



Back-shoulder: throw behind him

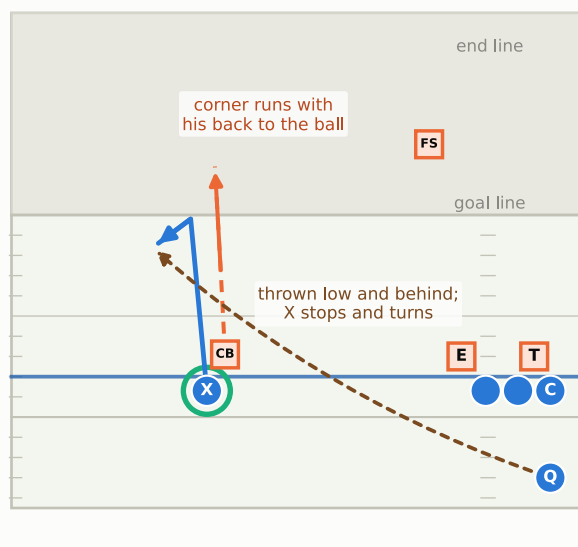


Figure 4: Two throws from one route, from the opponent's 8. Left, the fade: the corner (CB) presses with inside leverage, so X releases outside and the ball is dropped over his outside shoulder toward the back pylon, where the corner, trailing underneath, can't see it and the safety in the middle of the end zone can't reach it in time. Right, the back-shoulder throw: this corner runs with X stride for stride, on his inside hip, to take away the fade. The ball is thrown early, low and behind X's outside shoulder, away from the corner; X stops, turns and catches it near the goal line, and the corner, running with his back to the ball, is carried past.

The fade is famous for being thrown too often. It looks easy (one receiver, one defender, a jump ball) and it fails a lot: the ball has to be put in a small space near the sideline and the end line, and a corner who stays on the receiver's hip can knock it away at the last moment. In 2022–2025, passes thrown into the end zone toward the outside from inside the 10, a rough stand-in for fades and back-shoulder throws that the public data can't separate, were completed 40% of the time, against 68% for throws that stayed short of the goal line.⁵ Most of those end-zone completions are touchdowns, so the fade is a gamble with a big payoff, not a bad play; but a team that calls it on third-and-goal every week is choosing a coin flip.

i Film room: Green Bay Packers, the Rodgers–Nelson years (2010s)

The back-shoulder throw belongs to many quarterbacks, but its most famous partnership was Aaron Rodgers and Jordy Nelson in Mike McCarthy's Green Bay offense. The Packers' Hall of Fame profile of Nelson notes that the throw began as a red-zone play and that the two of them took it all over the field; Nelson, 6-foot-3, described it as a reaction rather than a set call: no signal, no pre-snap adjustment, just the ball arriving behind him when the corner ran too well.⁶ **What to notice:** the receiver's head. On a fade he keeps running and looks up late; on a back-shoulder throw he snaps his head around early, sinks his hips, and the corner keeps running. If you see a corner win a fade early in a game, watch for the back-shoulder throw against him next time.

The slant, and leverage

If the corner shades *outside* to take away the fade, the receiver has the inside, and the quick slant (two steps up, then a sharp break inside) is the answer. It is caught a yard or two into the end zone, in the space between the corner and whoever is playing the middle, before either can close. Put the two together and you have the red zone's first lesson about leverage: **the corner can take away the fade or the slant, not both**, and the receiver's release attacks the side he gives up.

⁵This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2022–2025 regular seasons, passes thrown from the opponent's 10 or closer (sacks excluded). "Into the end zone" = air yards at least the distance to the goal line; "toward the outside" = the scorer's `pass_location` left or right. The data cannot identify the route, so this group includes corner routes and other throws as well as fades and back-shoulder throws.

⁶Packers.com, Hall of Fame profile of Jordy Nelson (the back-shoulder throw "began as a red-zone play" and the Rodgers–Nelson combination used it all over the field): <https://www.packers.com/history/hof/jordy-nelson> ; Rob Demovsky, "The secrets of the back-shoulder fade," ESPN Packers blog (Nelson on the throw as a reaction rather than a signalled call): https://www.espn.com/blog/green-bay-packers/post/_/id/14582/the-secrets-of-the-back-shoulder-fade .

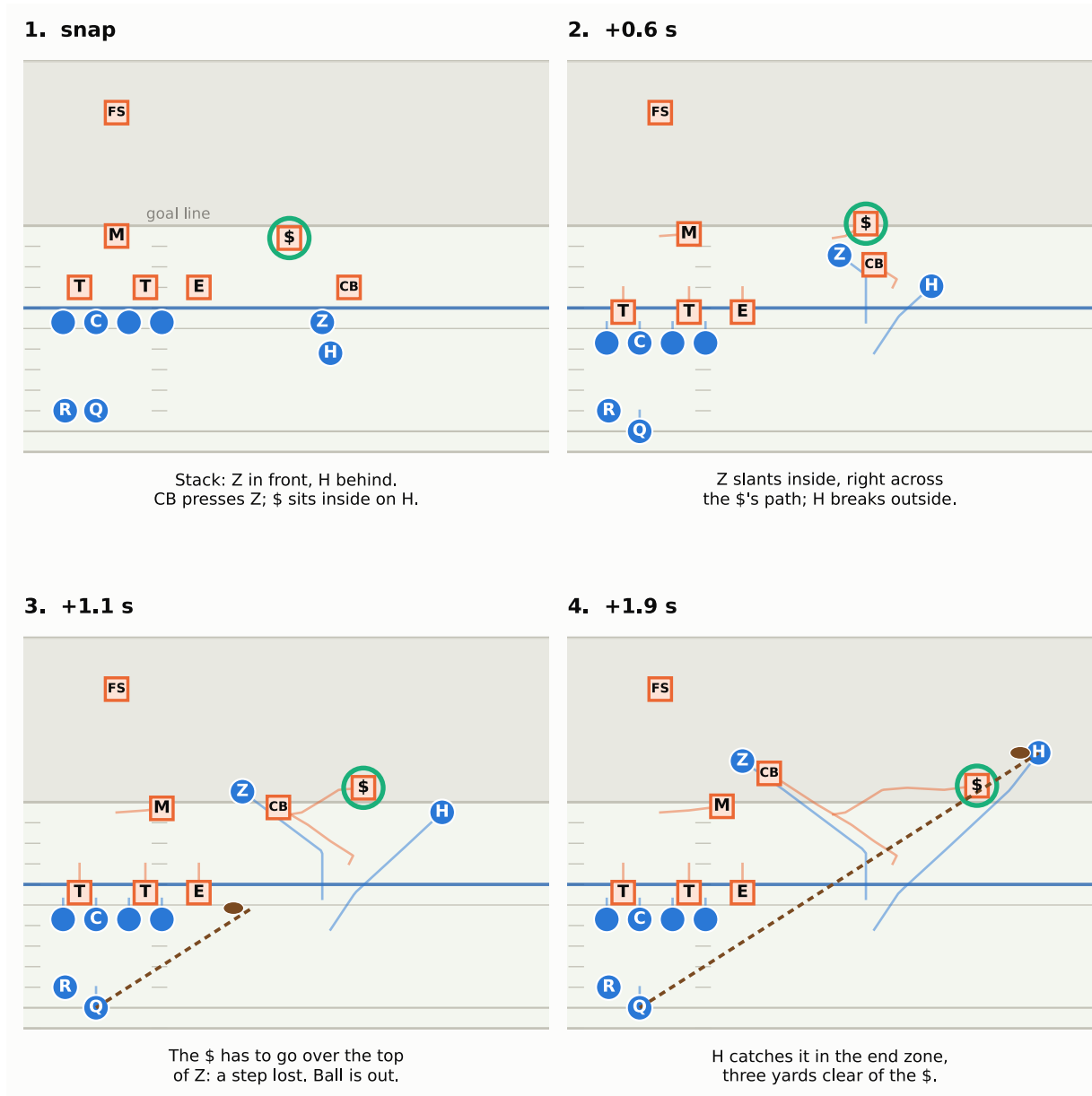


Figure 6: A stack rub against man coverage from the opponent's 4, simulated (BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron, not recorded). Z, the front of the stack, runs a slant inside. H, a step behind him, runs out toward the pylon. The corner (CB) presses Z and goes with him. The nickel (\$, ringed green), lined up inside and deeper to cover H, has to cross Z's path to follow H outside; Z never blocks him, he just runs his route, but the nickel must go over the top of him and loses a step. The ball is out at 0.6 seconds, before the nickel has recovered; by the catch, in the end zone near the pylon, H is about three yards clear.

When does a rub become a pick? The receiver in front may run his route; he may not *block*. The NFL calls offensive pass interference on a receiver who deliberately initiates contact with a defender more than one yard past the line of scrimmage, before the pass is touched, to get a teammate open. So offenses teach the rub man to run *through the defender's path* rather than at the defender, and to keep running, and they design the crossing to happen as close to the line as they can. Officials judge intent at full speed, and a quarterback can't know in advance whether the flag will come, which is part of why rubs are both effective and maddening.

How defenses answer. The cleanest answer is not to be in pure man. Against a stack or bunch, defenders can play a **banjo**: instead of each locking onto one receiver before the snap, they decide at the release, the outside defender taking whoever breaks outside and the inside defender whoever breaks inside, so nobody has to fight through the traffic. Another answer is to stop the rub at its source: a defender who jams the front receiver at the line knocks the traffic out of the way before it can form. That second answer decided a Super Bowl.

February 1, 2015, Glendale, Arizona. The Patriots led 28–24, and Seattle had the ball second-and-goal at New England’s 1 with about 26 seconds left and one timeout. Instead of handing off to Marshawn Lynch, Seattle threw: Jermaine Kearse ran a pick route on the right side to clear space for Ricardo Lockette’s slant behind him. Patriots cornerback Brandon Browner jammed Kearse at the line, so the rub never happened, and rookie Malcolm Butler, who had read the route, drove in front of Lockette and intercepted Russell Wilson’s pass at the goal line. New England won 28–24.⁷ **What to notice:** every ingredient of this chapter. A rub against man coverage near the goal line; a slant thrown into the middle, where defenders live; and the defense’s answer to the rub, a press jam that removed the traffic. The call was second-guessed for years, but the concept was a standard one. It failed because one defender beat the rub at the line and another read it.

The shovel pass

The **shovel pass** is a run play that happens to be a pass. The quarterback takes the snap and moves sideways along the line, as if rolling out or keeping the ball; a teammate (a tight end, a back, sometimes a slot receiver) comes across just in front of him, behind the line of scrimmage, and the quarterback flips the ball to him underhand. The receiver then runs behind a pulling lineman into the gap the defense has just vacated.

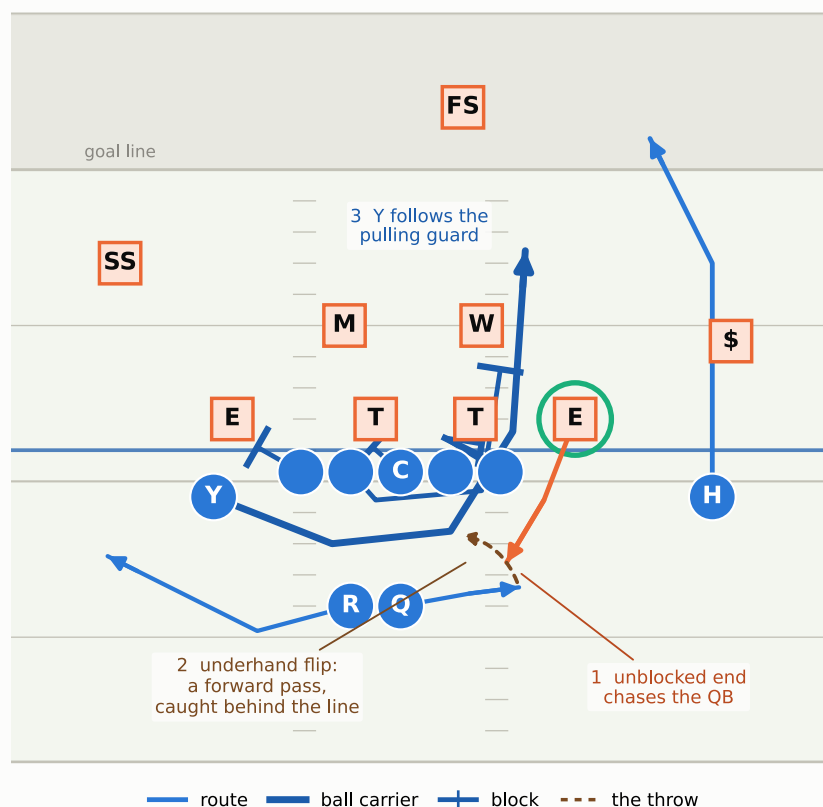


Figure 7: A shovel pass from the opponent’s 9. The play-side end (E, ringed) is left unblocked on purpose; he rushes at the quarterback, who steps right as if to run or throw. The left guard pulls across. The tight end (Y), lined up as a wing on the left, crosses behind the line and takes an underhand flip from the quarterback (brown dashes), a forward pass caught behind the line of scrimmage, then follows the guard up into the gap the unblocked end has just left. The running back swings the other way, and H’s route takes the nickel (\$) out of the picture.

Why does it work so well near the goal line? Because goal-line defenses are built to *attack*. Defensive ends charge upfield at a rolling quarterback; linebackers fly toward the first thing they see. The shovel pass turns that aggression into empty space: the end who chases the quarterback has taken himself out of the gap the ball is about to come through. And because the flip is a forward pass caught behind the line of scrimmage, the linemen can block downfield as on any run (the rule against linemen downfield

⁷Super Bowl XLIX, February 1, 2015, University of Phoenix Stadium, Glendale, Arizona: New England 28, Seattle 24. Second-and-goal from the 1, Kearse’s pick route and Lockette’s slant, Browner’s jam at the line and Butler’s interception: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XLIX.

only applies to passes that cross the line), while a dropped flip is merely an incomplete pass, not a fumble. College spread offenses made the shovel option famous; in the NFL it is a change-up, used a few times a season, usually near the goal line or on a short third down.

i Film room: Kansas City Chiefs 2017 (Week 2 vs. Philadelphia)

Andy Reid's offenses have used the shovel pass for years, and one of the best-known came in September 2017, when Kansas City's go-ahead touchdown in a 27–20 win over the Eagles was a 15-yard shovel pass to tight end Travis Kelce through the middle of Philadelphia's defense.⁸ **What to notice:** a red-zone play from the 15 that looks, for the first half-second, like a quarterback keep or a rollout. The shovel's whole design is to make the defense's most aggressive players wrong.

Two-point plays: designing a play from the 2

After a touchdown, the scoring team gets one more snap, a **try**. It can kick an extra point for one point or run a play from the 2-yard line for two: the **two-point conversion**. The NFL adopted it in 1994, borrowing it from college football (which snaps its try from the 3) and the old AFL. In 2015 the league moved the extra-point kick back to the 15-yard line, turning a near-automatic kick into a 33-yard attempt, and began letting the defense score two points by returning a failed try to the other end zone.⁹ (The rules are unchanged for 2026: still snapped from the 2.) *Whether* to go for two, and when the scoreboard demands it, belongs to The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down. This section is about *what to call*.

From 2015 to 2025, NFL teams converted 47% of their 1,297 regular-season two-point tries (counting only tries that produced a run or a pass, not the ones wiped out by penalties). Runs converted 55% of the time, passes 44%, yet teams passed on about 73% of tries.¹⁰ Why not run every time?

Part of the answer is selection. The teams that run on two-point tries are mostly the ones built to: a running quarterback, a heavy line, a reliable short-yardage play. Passes include the desperate tries late in games, when everyone knows the offense needs two and the defense has called its best pass defense. The bigger part is game theory. A two-point try is a single snap the defense knows is coming, from a spot it has studied all week. If an offense ran every time, defenses would load the box with every man they have, and the run rate would fall. The value of a two-point play depends on what the defense expects, and the best calls are ones that work against more than one defense.

That gives a simple design rule for a two-point play: **two good options that put one defender in conflict**, ideally a run threat and a pass, or a man-beater and a zone-beater on the same snap. Here are four common shapes.

⁸Kansas City 27, Philadelphia 20, September 17, 2017 (Week 2), Arrowhead Stadium; Kelce's 15-yard shovel-pass touchdown: *Philadelphia Inquirer* live coverage, <https://www.inquirer.com/philly/sports/eagles/live-updates-philadelphia-eagles-kansas-city-chiefs-nfl-score-andy-reid-carson-wentz-20170917.html>; Fox 29, "Kansas City Chiefs, Andy Reid beat Eagles 27-20": <https://www.fox29.com/news/kansas-city-chiefs-andy-reid-beat-eagles-27-20>.

⁹Pro Football Hall of Fame, "2-point conversion turns 30 years old" (adopted 1994, line at the 2; Tom Tupa scored the first one): <https://www.profootballhof.com/news/2024/09/2-point-conversion-turns-30-years-old>; CBS Sports, "NFL rule change: Extra point moved back, defenses can score" (2015: extra-point snap moved to the 15, defense may return a failed try for two points): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/nfl-rule-change-extra-point-moved-back-defenses-can-score>. No change to the two-point spot was proposed for 2026.

¹⁰This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2015–2025 regular seasons: two-point tries (`two_point_attempt`) whose play was recorded as a run or a pass, success from `two_point_conv_result`. Scrambles and sacks count as passes. Tries erased by penalties are left out.

i Film room: New England, Super Bowl LI (2016 season)

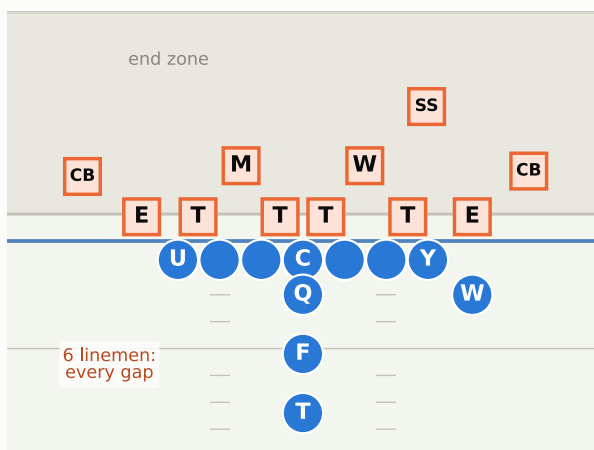
Down 28–3 in the third quarter against Atlanta, the Patriots needed two two-point conversions just to tie, and got both. The first, after Danny Amendola’s touchdown catch made it 28–18 with about six minutes left, was a direct snap to running back James White, who ran it in for 28–20. The second, after White’s own 1-yard touchdown run with 58 seconds left, was a quick throw from Tom Brady to Amendola for 28–28. New England won in overtime, 34–28.¹¹ **What to notice:** two different answers on the same night, a run with the quarterback out of the play and a quick pass; a defense that had seen one couldn’t sit on it the next time.

Goal-line personnel: the biggest people on the field

Inside the 3 or so, both teams change their players. The offense brings in its heaviest personnel: two or three tight ends, a fullback, sometimes a sixth offensive lineman reporting as an eligible receiver (a jumbo package), and sometimes a defensive lineman playing fullback. The most famous of those was William “The Refrigerator” Perry, the Chicago Bears’ rookie defensive tackle, who scored a 1-yard touchdown in Super Bowl XX in January 1986.¹² The idea is simple arithmetic: every receiver taken off the field is replaced by a blocker, so the offense can match the defense body for body near the ball.

The defense answers in kind with a **goal-line defense**: extra linemen and linebackers in place of defensive backs, everyone lined up close to the ball, every gap along the line filled before the snap. The two classic shapes are the **6-2** (six down linemen, two linebackers, three defensive backs) and the **5-3** (five down linemen, three linebackers, three defensive backs). Both put eight defenders within about three yards of the ball.

6-2 goal line



5-3 goal line

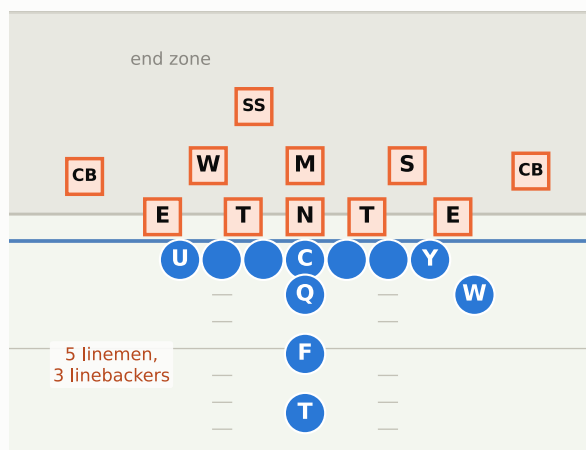


Figure 9: Goal-line personnel on both sides, ball on the 1. The offense is in 23 personnel (a fullback F and a tailback T, plus three tight ends: Y and U on the line and W as a wing), with tight line splits. Left, a 6-2 goal-line defense: six linemen in the gaps along the line, low, plus two linebackers behind them and three defensive backs for the tight ends and the wing. Right, a 5-3: a nose tackle (N) on the center, four more linemen, three linebackers. Both fill every gap from tight end to tight end at the snap. The defenders’ letters show their usual positions; on goal-line snaps the labels matter less than the gaps.

Football coaches have a three-word rule for this part of the field: **low man wins**. When two big men collide at the line, the one whose pads are lower gets under the other, lifts him and drives him back. On an ordinary down that matters; at the goal line it is almost everything, because the play will be decided within a yard of the ball. So goal-line defensive linemen often line up in four-point stances, both hands on the ground, and fire *under* the blockers, aiming to knock the offensive line back into the backfield and create a pile the runner can’t cross. Linebackers fill whatever gap is left, often by going over the top of the pile.

¹¹Super Bowl LI, February 5, 2017, NRG Stadium, Houston: New England 34, Atlanta 28 (OT). Fourth-quarter conversions: James White on a direct snap after Amendola’s 6-yard touchdown catch (28–20, 5:56 left); Brady to Amendola after White’s 1-yard touchdown run (28–28, 0:58 left): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LI.

¹²Super Bowl XX, January 26, 1986, Louisiana Superdome, New Orleans: Chicago 46, New England 10; Perry’s 1-yard touchdown run came in the third quarter: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XX.

! Why it exists

A goal-line defense exists because near the goal line the run is a real threat on every snap and the pass has little room to hurt you. Trading cornerbacks and safeties for linemen and linebackers trades coverage, which the compressed field has made cheap, for gap control and size, which the last yard has made precious. **What it gives up:** coverage. Goal-line defenses are built to stop a run up the middle, and their worst nightmare is the play that looks exactly like that run and isn't: the play-action pass to a tight end or a fullback slipping out, or a quarterback rollout to the edge where fewer defenders are standing. That is why heavy offensive personnel throws more often near the goal line than you'd guess.

The quarterback sneak

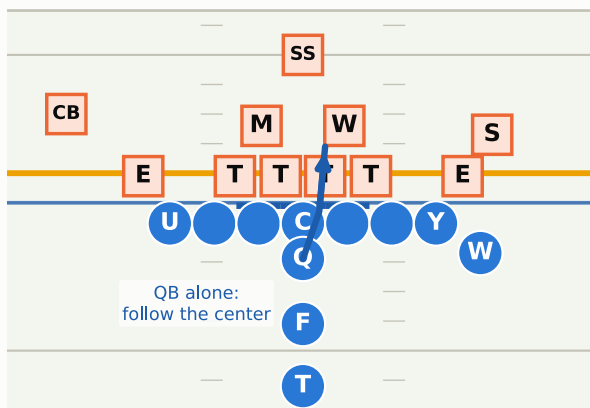
The shortest play in football is the **QB sneak**. The quarterback takes the snap under center and immediately drives forward behind his center, usually into one of the gaps beside him, to gain a yard or less. No handoff, no fake, no read.

It is the most reliable play in the book for one yard, and the reasons are worth spelling out:

- **The ball starts closest to the line.** On a handoff, the ball goes backward to a running back five to seven yards deep, who then has to gain all of that back before he gains anything. On a sneak, the ball is a foot behind the line when the quarterback has it.
- **It is the fastest play there is.** The ball goes from the center's hands to the quarterback's and forward in a fraction of a second, before linebackers can read the play and fill.
- **The quarterback is the extra blocker's dividend.** On every other run, the quarterback hands off and stops being a factor; on the sneak he *is* the runner, so every other player can block, the same extra-hat arithmetic as QB power.
- **The defense can't see it coming any differently.** A quarterback under center on third-and-1 might sneak, hand off, or fake and throw. Defenses have to defend all three.

And its blocking is simple: the center and guards drive straight ahead, often double-teaming whoever lines up over the center, and everyone else on the line fires low and forward. Sneaks are often run on a quick count, before the defense has settled into its stances.

Quarterback sneak



Tush push

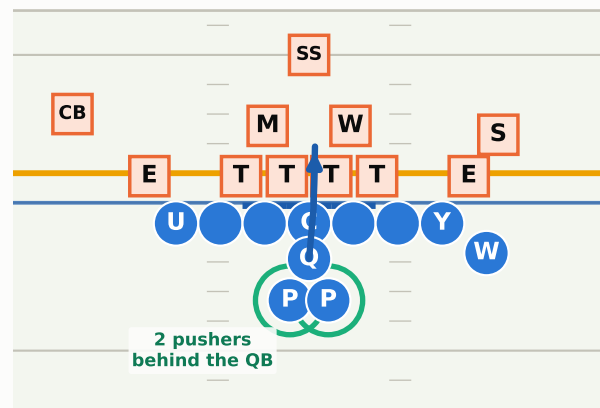


Figure 10: Two ways to gain a yard, third-and-1. Left, the classic quarterback sneak: the quarterback (Q) alone under center, the tailback deep. At the snap the center and guards drive forward and the quarterback follows his center into the nearest crease, here the right A gap, between center and guard. Right, the tush push: the same quarterback sneak, but two teammates (P) line up directly behind the quarterback, and at the snap they drive into him and shove the whole pile forward. The tight ends (Y, U) and wings (W) join in on the line or behind it. The defense, crowding the A gaps, lines up the same way against both. The yellow line is the line to gain, one yard away.

i Film room: Tom Brady's sneak (2000–2022)

No quarterback is more associated with the sneak than Tom Brady, a 6-foot-4 pocket passer who was never fast and never needed to be. Counting every run he made with a yard or less to go, regular season and playoffs, nflverse play-by-play has Brady carrying 187 times and gaining the first down or the touchdown on 86% of them; almost all were sneaks.¹³ **What to notice on old Patriots film:** how *quickly* Brady snapped it. The offense often lined up and went on the first sound, before the defense had its hands down, and Brady was over the center's back before the linebackers had moved. Speed of execution, not size, made his sneak work.

The tush push

The **tush push** is a quarterback sneak with help from behind. Two or three teammates (usually a running back and a tight end, sometimes a third player) line up directly behind the quarterback, and at the snap they drive into him and push. The offensive line fires low and forward; the quarterback, crouched behind his center, surges into the line; the pushers add their weight from behind, and the whole mass moves forward, usually just far enough. Philadelphia fans called it the Brotherly Shove.

¹³This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2000–2022, regular season and playoffs: runs with Tom Brady as the ball carrier on 1 yard (or less) to go, kneel-downs excluded; "converted" = first down or touchdown. Most (about 83%) were logged as runs up the middle, the sneak's signature; the rest went just left or right of center.

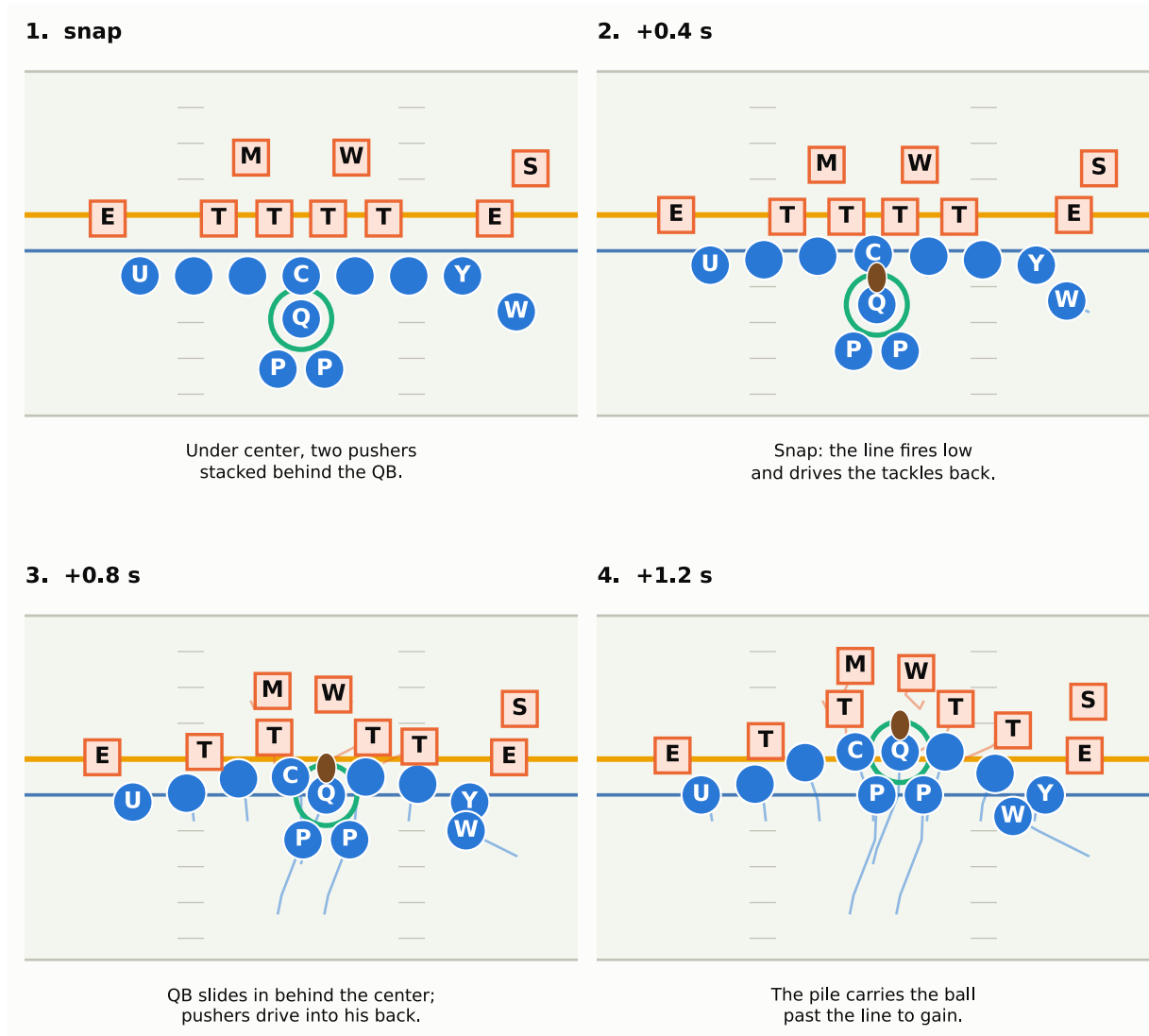


Figure 11: The tush push, simulated (BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron, not recorded): third-and-1 at the opponent's 35. 1: the quarterback (ringed) is under center with two pushers (P) directly behind him. 2: at the snap, the offensive line fires low into the defensive linemen before they can rise. 3: the center and right guard drive the two A-gap tackles back and apart, the quarterback slides into the seam behind them, and the pushers drive into his back; the linebackers (M, W) come forward to meet the pile at the top. 4: the pile, still moving as one, carries the ball (brown) past the yellow line. The play is decided in about a second and a yard and a half. Markers are drawn a little smaller than in the other diagrams so that engaged players stay visible.

Why does a shove from behind help that much? Physics, mostly. A sneak is a pushing contest at the line: the offense's linemen and quarterback against the defense's linemen and linebackers, both sides trying to move a pile a yard. Two pushers behind the quarterback add a few hundred pounds of driving force at exactly the point of the contest, and they add it *immediately*, at the snap, before the defense's second level can arrive. The defense can't add the same force, because its extra bodies have to come from the other side of a pile they can't get into. And the quarterback, pushed from behind, can stay low and keep his feet driving instead of being stopped upright by the first linebacker to hit him.

How it became legal: assisting the runner

For most of the NFL's history, the tush push was illegal. The rule on **assisting the runner** said teammates could not push or pull a ball carrier forward; through the 2004 season it was a 10-yard foul. In 2005 the NFL removed "push" from the rule and kept the ban on *pulling*. The reason was practical: in a pile, officials could never tell who was pushing whom (a runner, a teammate in contact with the runner, the pile itself), so the rule was close to unenforceable. As former officiating chief Mike Pereira put it, pushing was

¹⁴Mike Pereira, quoted in *Boston Globe* coverage of the tush push's history (April 2, 2025): <https://www.bostonglobe.com/2025/04/02/sports/nfl-tush-push-rule/>; the pre-2005 rule (a 10-yard foul to push or pull a runner) and the 2005 removal of "push": ESPN, "Sources: Tush push ban vote tabled by

“really too difficult to officiate,” so the league simply made it legal.¹⁴ Pulling is still a foul: a teammate who grabs the runner’s arm or jersey and hauls him forward costs his team 10 yards. Watch for it in a tush-push pile. The college rulebook followed in 2013.¹⁵

That 2005 date carries a footnote of its own. On October 15, 2005, USC’s Matt Leinart scored the winning touchdown at Notre Dame with running back Reggie Bush shoving him across the goal line from behind, the “Bush Push.” College rules still banned pushing then, no flag was thrown, and the play became a legend: the illegal, unforgettable ancestor of a play that is now legal in the NFL.¹⁶

For almost two decades after the change, NFL teams pushed runners only in passing, as piles formed. Then the Philadelphia Eagles turned it into a designed play.

i Film room: Philadelphia Eagles, 2022–2025

Starting in 2022, Philadelphia ran the push more often and more reliably than anyone had, with the right ingredients: Jalen Hurts, a quarterback with exceptional leg strength; center Jason Kelce, small for a center but famously quick off the ball and low; an elite line around him, including right tackle Lane Johnson; and line coach Jeff Stoutland, who drilled the timing. On 1 yard to go, FTN’s charters flagged 51% of the Eagles’ 2022–2025 snaps as quarterback sneaks or pushes, against a league median of 14%; counting every Hurts carry with a yard or less to go, nflverse has him converting 83% of 179 tries.¹⁷ Kelce retired after the 2023 season and the play kept working, and Hurts scored the first touchdown of Super Bowl LIX (February 2025, a 40–22 win over Kansas City) on a tush push.¹⁸ **What to notice:** the snap. The Eagles’ line moves as one at the exact instant of the snap, and the defensive linemen are already being driven back before they have risen out of their stances. The push from behind finishes a play that the line’s timing has mostly won already. (The Eagles’ push as a talent and coaching advantage, and how it compares with the rest of the league, is the subject of *The Eagles: Trenches, RPOs, and the Tush Push*.)

The ban debate

The push’s success made it controversial. Critics made three arguments: **safety** (a pile of the heaviest players on the field driving forward with heads down), **aesthetics** (a near-automatic yard is dull football), and **fairness** (one team’s mastery of a play is a reason to rethink it). Defenders of the play answered that injuries on it were rare, that other teams could copy it, and that you don’t ban a play for being executed well.

In 2025 Green Bay proposed banning any pushing, pulling, lifting or grasping of the runner. The proposal was tabled at the spring league meeting; a revised version came to a vote on May 21, 2025, and **failed 22–10**, two votes short of the 24 needed (rule changes need three-quarters of the 32 owners). The league tightened its officiating guidance instead, on false starts and on how players line up for the play. For 2026, **no team proposed a ban**; the competition committee’s co-chairman said in February 2026 that he didn’t expect one, and the league said it would only “lightly” revisit how the play is officiated. The tush push is legal for the 2026 season.¹⁹

NFL owners”: https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/44490292/sources-tush-push-ban-vote-tabled-nfl-owners . Current rule: *Official Playing Rules of the National Football League* (2026), Rule 12, Section 1, Article 4 (assisting the runner: no pulling; 10 yards).

¹⁵The NCAA deleted “push” from its corresponding rule for the 2013 season, matching the NFL’s 2005 change; see the history summarized in *Acme Packing Company*, “Banning the tush push is a return to classic football, not a departure from it” (May 21, 2025): <https://www.acmepackingcompany.com/2025/5/21/24434447/banning-the-tush-push-is-a-return-to-classic-football-not-a-departure-from-it> .

¹⁶ESPN, “The Reggie Bush Push: USC–Notre Dame rivalry legacy, 20 years later” (2025): https://africa.espn.com/college-football/story/_/id/46592420/reggie-bush-push-usc-notre-dame-rivalry-legacy-20-years-later-2025 . USC won 34–31 at Notre Dame on October 15, 2005.

¹⁷This book’s calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting, 2022–2025 regular seasons: share of each team’s runs and dropbacks on 1 yard to go flagged `is_qb_sneak` (kneel-downs excluded). Hurts: nflverse play-by-play, 2020–2025, regular season and playoffs, runs with Jalen Hurts as the ball carrier for Philadelphia on 1 yard or less to go, kneel-downs excluded.

¹⁸Super Bowl LIX, February 9, 2025, Caesars Superdome, New Orleans: Philadelphia 40, Kansas City 22; Hurts’s first-quarter touchdown on the tush push: <https://www.cbsnews.com/amp/news/nfl-mvp-super-bowl-jalen-hurts-eagles> .

¹⁹2025 proposal tabled at the spring meeting and the revised version’s 22–10 failure on May 21, 2025: *SI*, “Packers’ proposal to ban Eagles’ tush push fails again”: <https://www.si.com/nfl/packers/packers-proposal-to-ban-eagles-tush-push-fails-again> , and *Philadelphia Inquirer*: <https://www.inquirer.com/eagles/eagles-tush-push-packers-ban-vote-20250519.html> ; no proposal for 2026 and McKay’s comments: NFL.com, <https://www.nfl.com/news/competition-committee-co-chairman-rich-mckay-doesn-t-expect-tush-push-ban-proposal-in-2026> ; Troy Vincent on revisiting officiating “lightly”: *The Washington Times* (Feb. 24, 2026), <https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2026/feb/24/nfl-receives-no-tush-push-ban-proposal-year-effort-last-year-ban/> .

Common misconception

“The tush push is unstoppable.” It isn’t, and the next section’s numbers show that. Defenses stop it by winning the same contest the offense is trying to win: timing the snap so their linemen get *under* the offensive line first, crowding both A gaps beside the center, and sending linebackers over the top to meet the quarterback before the pile moves (going over the pile on a running play is legal; the NFL’s leaping restrictions apply to kicks). Defensive linemen also try to jump the snap count, accepting the occasional offside penalty for the chance of getting into the backfield early. What the push does is shift the odds of a one-yard contest, and on one yard that shift is worth a great deal.

Does it work? The sneak in the data

FTN’s charting service marks every play it thinks was a quarterback sneak (`is_qb_sneak`), and the flag covers the plain sneak and the push alike, because FTN does not chart them separately. So the numbers below are for sneaks of every kind.²⁰

On 1 yard to go, 2022–2025 regular seasons, sneaks gained the first down or the touchdown 81% of the time (1,089 plays). Other runs on 1 yard to go converted 70%, and passes 58%. A gap of 11 percentage points on a play that decides whether a drive lives is an enormous difference. With 2 yards to go, sneaks were far rarer and far less successful (54% of 37), which tells you what the play is for: the last yard, not the last two.

²⁰FTN charting via nflverse `load_ftn_charting()` (2022 onward). FTN’s data dictionary has no separate tush-push flag; `is_qb_sneak` covers both: https://nflreadr.nflverse.com/articles/dictionary_ftn_charting.html. The sneak rates here count plays FTN flagged and nflverse recorded as runs, on 1 (or 2) yards to go, 2022–2025 regular seasons; “converted” = first down or touchdown on the play. Other runs exclude scrambles and kneel-downs; passes include sacks and scrambles. By season, sneaks on 1 yard to go converted 85% (2022), 80% (2023), 83% (2024), 78% (2025).

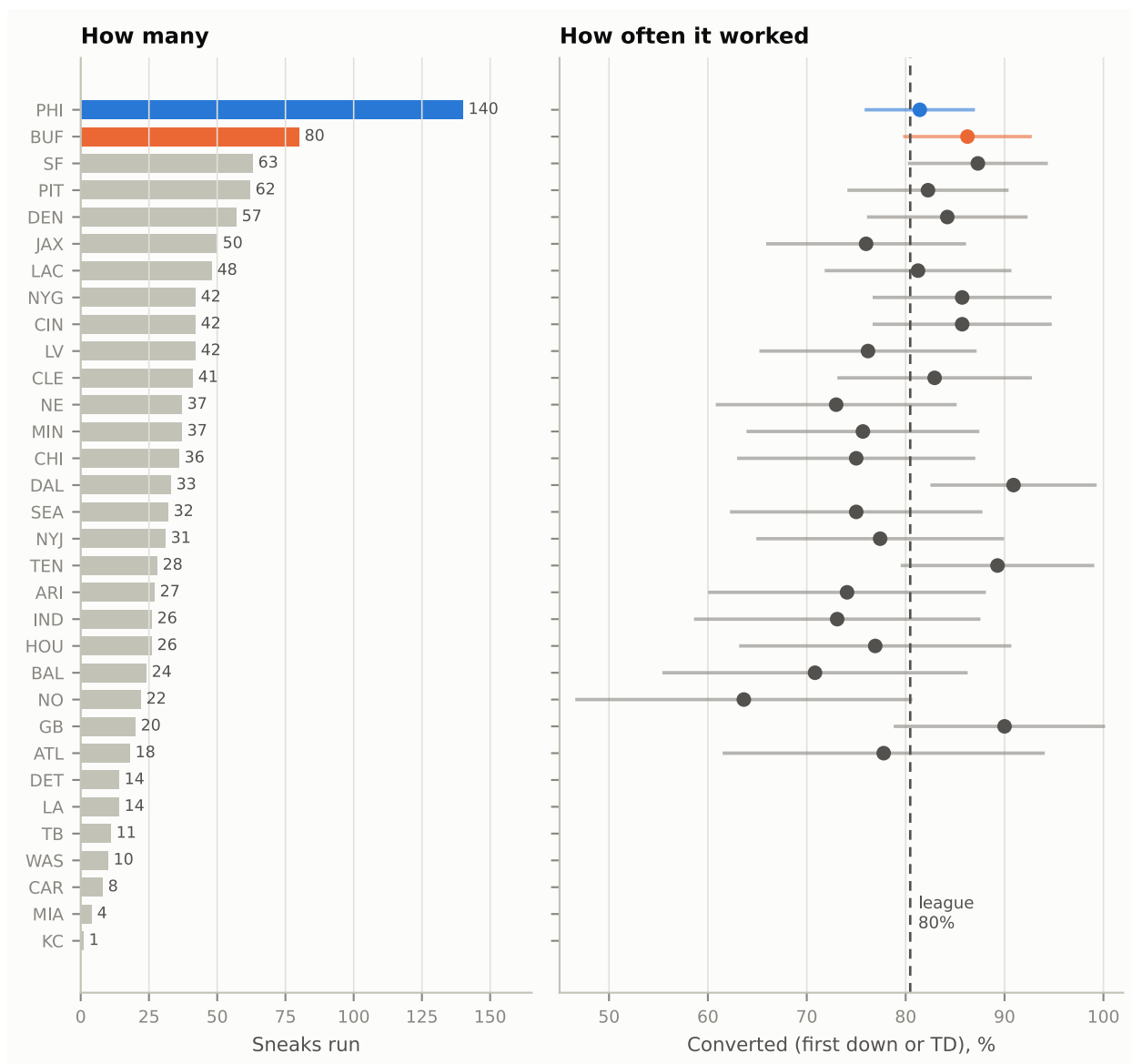


Figure 12: Quarterback sneaks (including tush pushes) on 1 or 2 yards to go, by team, 2022–2025 regular seasons. Left: how many each team ran. Right: the share that gained a first down or a touchdown, with a bar showing the range that chance alone could easily produce (a 90% interval) around each team’s rate; teams with fewer than 15 attempts are left out of the right panel. The dashed line is the league rate. Philadelphia (blue) ran far more than anyone; Buffalo (orange) was second. Most teams’ rates sit within noise of the league average: small samples make sneak rankings unreliable. Data: nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting (is_qb_sneak).

Two lessons hide in that chart. First, **volume, not rate, is what separates the teams**. Most teams’ conversion rates overlap once you account for sample size: 40 sneaks is not enough to tell an 80% team from an 85% team. What differs enormously is how often teams *call* the play, and the Eagles stand alone there. Second, **a high rate is partly selection**. Teams sneak when the distance is truly short, often inches rather than a full yard, and most teams sneak only when they like the look. The Eagles, calling it on about half their 1-yard downs, were sneaking into defenses that knew it was coming, which makes their rate more impressive than the raw number suggests.

i Film room: Buffalo Bills and Josh Allen (2018–2025)

Buffalo's version of the short-yardage quarterback run starts with the quarterback himself: Josh Allen, one of the biggest and strongest quarterbacks in the league, who sneaks, pushes and runs QB power with equal comfort. In FTN's charting the Bills ran the second-most sneaks of 2022–2025, and on every Allen carry with a yard or less to go since he entered the league, nflverse has him converting 86% of 181 tries, a hair better than Brady's career mark.²¹ **What to notice:** where Allen goes. A pure sneak goes straight ahead; Allen often bounces a step to the A or B gap where the pile is softest, using his size like a running back's.

Putting it together: a red-zone possession

Here is how the pieces fit on one drive. First-and-10 at the opponent's 18: the defense still has some depth to protect, so you'll see two-high safeties, zone coverage and the offense's normal playbook. A completion to the 7 makes it first-and-goal, and the picture changes: the safeties come down, the corners press, and the coverage is mostly man. The offense answers with quick throws: a slant or a fade on the outside if it likes a matchup, a rub from a bunch if it sees man, a sprint-out if it wants an easy read. Inside the 3, both teams change personnel: jumbo against goal-line defense. Now it's a run, a quarterback sneak or push, or the play-action pass that the heavy personnel sets up. And if the drive ends in a touchdown, there's one more decision: kick, or one more play from the 2.

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: fade or rub?

When the ball crosses the 20

- Count the safeties. Two deep at the 18 is normal; one or none inside the 10 means the defense has traded depth for bodies near the ball.
- Look at the corners' depth. A corner a yard off the receiver is pressing: expect man coverage.

Inside the 10: read the receivers' splits

- **A receiver alone, wide, with 5 to 8 yards to the sideline?** That spacing is for a fade or back-shoulder throw. Check the corner's leverage: lined up inside him, think fade; outside him, think slant.
- **Receivers bunched or stacked, tight to the formation?** That's rub territory. Predict a crossing pattern against man, and watch whether the defenders switch (banjo) or chase through the traffic.
- **The quarterback in the gun with receivers flooded to one side?** Look for a sprint-out to that side.

Inside the 3

- Heavy personnel on both sides? Watch the quarterback: under center with players stacked directly behind him is a tush push; a fullback and tailback deep behind him is a handoff or play-action.
- On the push, watch the snap and the first half-second, not the pile: whichever line fires first and lower usually wins.

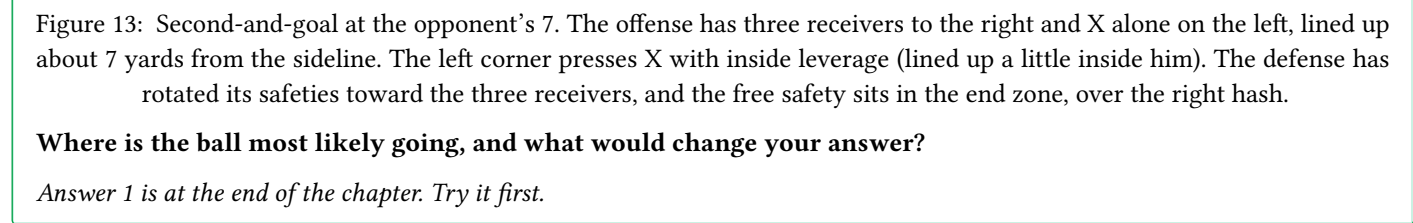
After a touchdown

- If the offense stays on the field, guess the concept before the snap from its formation: bunch (rub), spread with a back beside the quarterback (QB run or sprint-out), or heavy (run or play-action).

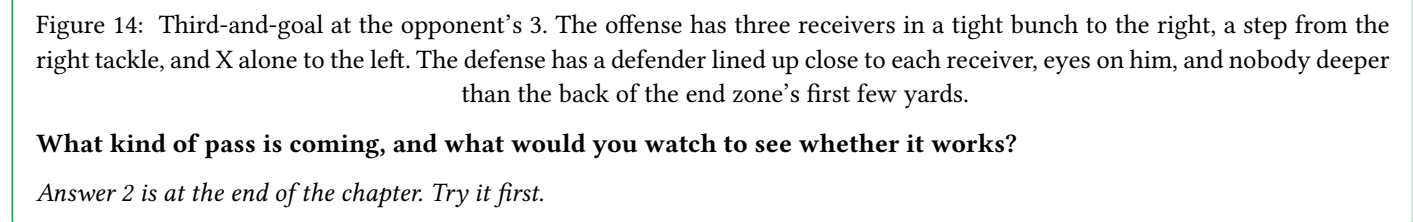
For your prediction log (01-06): inside the 10, write F (fade or back-shoulder), R (rub), Q (quick slant or out), S (sprint-out) or N (run) before each snap, from the splits alone.

²¹This book's calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2018–2025, regular season and playoffs: runs with Josh Allen as the ball carrier for Buffalo on 1 yard or less to go, kneel-downs excluded; "converted" = first down or touchdown. Team sneak counts: FTN is `is_qb_sneak`, as in the chart.

💡 Predict the play 1: the receiver alone



💡 Predict the play 2: tight bunch, no safety



💡 Predict the play 3: fourth-and-inches

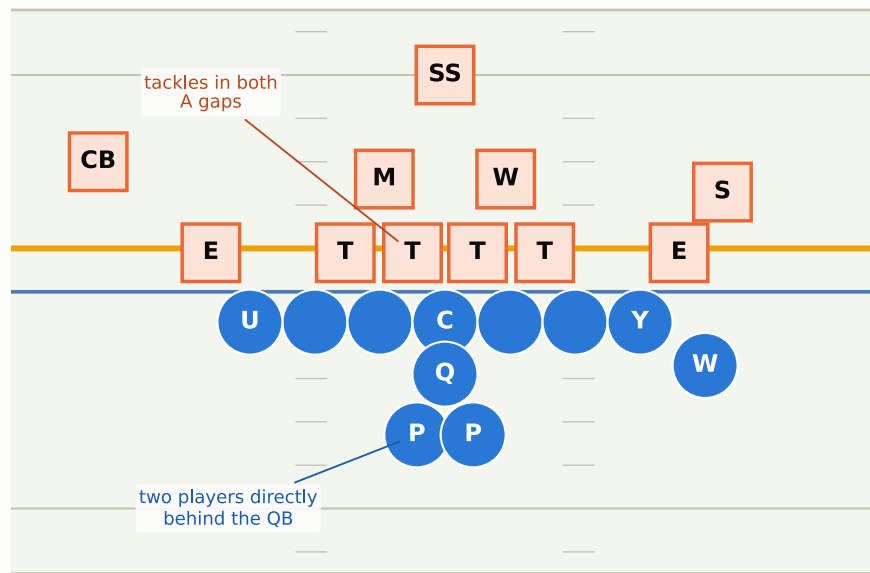


Figure 15: Fourth-and-1 (really less than a yard) at the opponent's 35, early in the third quarter. The quarterback is under center with two players stacked directly behind him and tight ends on both ends of the line. The defense has six linemen crouched low, two of them in the gaps beside the center, and its linebackers are creeping toward the line.

What is the offense running, how likely is it to work, and what will the defense try?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- Near the goal line the **end line becomes the deepest defender**. The compressed field squeezes zones, frees safeties to come down, and makes man coverage, press and Cover 0 cheap. The offense loses its deep threat, and every throw arrives into a crowd.
- Red-zone pass concepts win quickly and close: the **fade** and **back-shoulder throw** against press with no outside help, the **slant** when the corner takes away the fade, **rub**s from stacks and bunches against man, the **shovel pass** against an attacking front, and the **sprint-out** that puts a flat defender in conflict.
- A good **two-point play** gives the offense two answers that put one defender in conflict, so it works against more than one defensive call. Runs have converted more often than passes since 2015, partly because of who chooses to run.
- **Goal-line defenses** (6-2, 5-3) trade defensive backs for linemen and linebackers and fill every gap; low man wins. Their weakness is the play that looks like the run and isn't.
- The **QB sneak** is the best one-yard play in football: the ball starts closest to the line, the play is instant, and the quarterback-as-runner adds a blocker. The **tush push** adds pushers behind him; it has been legal since the NFL removed the ban on pushing the runner in **2005** (pulling is still a foul), survived a **22–10 ban vote in 2025**, and is legal in **2026**.
- In the data, about six red-zone trips in ten end in touchdowns; a first-and-goal from the 1 scores about nine times in ten; and sneaks convert about four in five on 1 yard to go. Teams differ far more in how often they sneak than in how well.

Connections

Builds on: Third Down (situational packages, the sticks), Contact Rules and Penalties as Strategy (pass interference and the rub-versus-pick line), Option Football (the quarterback as the extra hat), Man Coverage (Cover 0, press, banjo) and Dropback Concepts (rub routes).

Sets up:

- The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down: whether to go for two, the two-point chart, and when a short fourth down is worth the risk, which leans on the sneak numbers here.

- The Eagles: Trenches, RPOs, and the Tush Push: the tush push as a talent and coaching edge, and how the Eagles compare with the rest of the league.
- Appendix B, the Concept Atlas and Appendix C, the Defensive Atlas: one-page cards for the red-zone, two-point and short-yardage concepts, and for the goal-line fronts.

If you want to go deeper: Chris B. Brown’s *The Art of Smart Football* on red-zone passing and the leverage game; ESPN’s and the Packers’ pieces on the back-shoulder throw cited in this chapter; and any season’s goal-line snaps on the All-22 film, watched with nothing but the corners’ leverage and the receivers’ splits in mind.

i Go deeper

From simulation to real tracking data. The two animations in this chapter are gridiron simulations written in NFL Big Data Bowl (BDB) coordinates. The 2025 Big Data Bowl release (2022 season, weeks 1–9) has every player’s position ten times a second, before and after the snap, so you can find real quarterback sneaks and tush pushes (the Eagles ran plenty in those weeks) and draw them with the same code. The data lives on Kaggle and needs your own free login, so this cell is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

To X on the left, most likely a fade. Everything about the alignment points there. X is alone on his side, lined up with about 7 yards to the sideline, exactly the room a fade needs. The corner is pressing with inside leverage, which takes away the slant and gives up the outside release. And the safety help has rotated toward the three receivers on the right: the free safety is in the end zone over the far hash, much too far away to reach a ball thrown toward the left pylon a second after the snap. The three receivers on the right are there partly to *pull* that help away. Coaches call this a “backside” or isolation fade.

What would change it: if the corner bailed at the snap and ran with X over the top, the better throw is the back-shoulder: thrown early, behind X’s outside shoulder, near the goal line. If the corner had lined up outside X, the slant would be open instead. And if the free safety had stayed in the middle or shaded left, the quarterback would likely work the three-receiver side, where the defense would then be short a man.

Answer 2.

A rub out of the bunch, against man coverage. The defense has a defender lined up close to each bunch receiver, all eyes on their men, and no safety deep: that is man coverage, very likely Cover 0 or a Cover 1 with the free safety playing shallow. A tight bunch against man is built for exactly this: at the snap two of the three receivers cross underneath the third (or the point man runs into the defenders’ path), and one of the three defenders has to fight through the traffic. Expect the ball to go to the flat or the back pylon on the right, or on a quick in-breaking route underneath, within about a second.

What to watch: the three defenders at the snap. If they *switch* (the outside defender takes whoever breaks outside, the inside one whoever breaks inside), that’s a banjo, and the rub gains little; the quarterback should look for X alone on the left instead. If they each chase their own man, look for the one who has to go around a teammate: that’s the receiver who’ll be open. And if the front receiver stops and turns into a defender two yards downfield, look for a flag: that’s an illegal pick, not a rub.

Answer 3.

A tush push. A quarterback under center with two teammates lined up directly behind him on a short fourth down is the push’s signature alignment; a handoff would need a back five to seven yards deep. With less than a yard to go, history says the offense converts a large majority of the time: across the league in 2022–2025, sneaks and pushes on 1 yard to go succeeded about four times in five, and with only inches to go the odds are better still.

What the defense will try: to win the snap. Its tackles in the A gaps will try to fire under the center and guards before they can come off the ball; its linebackers are creeping up to time the snap and meet the quarterback at the top of the pile; and a lineman may gamble on jumping the count. The offense knows that, so watch for a hard count (the quarterback barking a long, loud cadence to draw the defense offside, which would give the first down for free) before it snaps the ball at all. One more thing to watch in the pile: a teammate *pulling* the quarterback forward by the arm or jersey. Pushing is legal; pulling is a 10-yard foul.